

Amiya Kumar Hajra

4/8/34 – 12/29/25



Amiya Kumar Hajra, a devoted family man and scientist, passed away on December 29, 2025. During his 91 years he achieved the American dream and was recognized as a pioneer in brain biochemistry research.

Amiya was a quiet trailblazer throughout his life. He was born in West Bengal, India as one of 12 siblings. He attended the University of Calcutta to study biochemistry, where his talents earned him admission to Northwestern University's PhD program. In classic "American Dream" style, in 1958 he was the first in his family to leave India and started his journey to the USA on an ox cart! From there he took two trains, then a two-week ship voyage to Italy, another train to France, a boat to England, a plane to New York City, and finally a bus to Chicago. He borrowed money from family and friends to make the trip.

In another bold move, he arrived in the USA well before the Immigration Act of 1965 opened the country to more non-Europeans, putting him on the leading edge of modern American immigration. After receiving his PhD, Amiya became an assistant professor at the University of Michigan in 1963, then earned tenure and enjoyed a prolific four-decade career at the University where he was an author on over 125 scientific papers, articles, and book contributions. He became a global expert in brain lipids, and his work included the discovery of the biological mechanics of Zellweger's Syndrome. In 1988 he received the nationally prestigious Javits Award in recognition of his contributions to neurological research. Amiya had an unquenchable thirst for knowledge and spent many evenings in his study reading and writing, as well as attending scientific conferences around the world. He was also a devoted professor who taught and collaborated with many students over the years. He leaves behind a more informed world thanks to his lifelong pursuit of knowledge.

He met his wife of 60 years, Manideepa (Moni), at an Indian community gathering in Michigan. In another trailblazing act, they rejected Indian expectations around arranged marriage and social caste to marry in 1965 (almost as shocking, Moni attended rival Michigan State University!). They made Ann Arbor their home base for six decades while keeping an apartment in Kolkata, India for many years. They helped found Mitali, a cultural organization that for decades has helped Indian Bengalis celebrate their heritage. As one of the few early Mitali members with a car, Amiya was often the welcome wagon for new arrivals at the Detroit airport.

Amiya and Moni had two sons, Amit and Neel, who grew up immersed in everything Ann Arbor had to offer. The family took regular road trips across Michigan and the country and enjoyed camping, fishing and grilling out in the summers. Amiya remained faithful to his relatives in India and highly philanthropic, helping to start a new elementary school in his home village while supporting many US charities. Amiya was the last of 12 siblings, and is survived by his wife Moni, his sons Amit (wife Laura) and Neel (wife Lisa), and his five grandchildren Nik, Vaughn, Arun, Ian, and Ella.

Amiya's *Shraddah* service (a Hindu ceremony to honor ancestors) will be held at Kalibari Temple in Warren, Michigan on Saturday, January 10 at 11 AM. Memorial donations may be made to the Hajra Family Fund at the Ann Arbor Area Community Foundation, a permanent charitable fund started in 2013 by Amiya and his family to forever support area nonprofits.